Anguimorph lizards

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Reptilia
ORDER	Squamata
SUBORDER	Lacertilia
SUPERFAMILY	Anguimorpha
FAMILIES	9
SPECIES	250

The anguimorphs include the largest of all lizards, the monitors, and the venomous lizards, the Mexican beaded lizard and the Gila monster. This diverse group also includes the slow worm and the glass lizards, among others. Anguimorphs are thought to be more evolved than other lizards, and it is likely that they were the ancestors of the snakes—many species have fanglike teeth and a long, forked tongue. Anguimorph lizards are distributed almost worldwide.

Anatomy

The largest group of anguimorph lizards are the anguids. These slender lizards have smooth scales, and many have small legs or no legs at all (as, for example, in the slow worm).

Monitor lizards are easily recognized by their long neck, narrow head with a pointed snout, powerful limbs, and muscular tail. They have a long, forked tongue, which they use to test their surroundings. This family contains some very large species, including the Komodo dragon.

The venomous lizards, the beaded lizards of North America, are heavily built and have a wide head with a blunt snout, short legs, and a swollen tail. Their venom enters wounds made by sharp fangs in the lower jaw. (Snakes' fangs are in the upper jaw.)

Hunting and feeding

Anguimorph lizards use various methods to find and overpower their prey. Like most lizards, the smaller species feed mainly on insects but some of the larger monitors can subdue large mammals, including pigs and deer. Monitors also feed on carrion and have an acute sense of smell, which they use to locate decaying flesh. The beaded lizards, too, hunt by smell, and will track prey over long distances, using their tongue to follow scent trails left by small mammals and birds. They also feed on the eggs of ground-nesting birds.

Reproduction

Anguimorph lizards may lay eggs or give birth to live young. Several species of monitors incubate their eggs in termite nests, using their strong claws to break into the mounds. When the termites repair the nest, the eggs are entombed in a controlled environment, protected from predators. They often hatch at the start of the rainy season, when the soil softens. Females of some species are thought to return to the mound to help the young break out.

HUNTING
For such large reptiles, monitor lizards can be remarkably agile. The mangrove monitor (shown here) spends a large part of its time in water but also hunts on land. It uses its strong claws to climb trees in search of prey such as this tree snake.

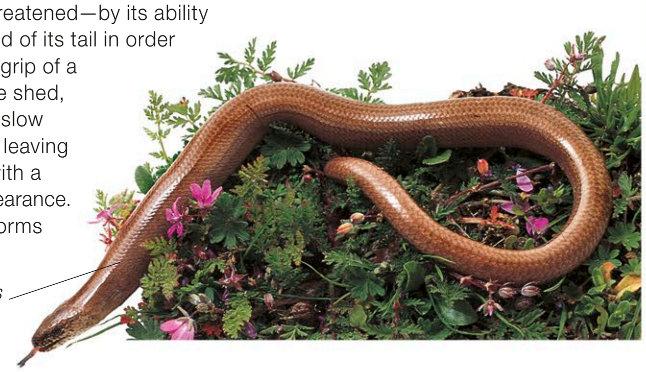
Anguis fragilis

Slow worm

Location Europe to W. Asia, N.W. Africa

Length 12–16 in (30–40 cm), max 20 in (50 cm)
Breeding Viviparous
Habit Terrestrial/ Burrowing
Status Not evaluated

With its smooth, scaly body and flickering tongue, this widespread legless lizard looks much more like a snake than a worm. At close quarters, it is easily distinguished from snakes by eyelids that can be closed, and—when threatened—by its ability to shed the end of its tail in order to escape the grip of a predator. Once shed, the tail is very slow to regenerate, leaving many adults with a truncated appearance. Young slow worms are often brightly colored, with a metallic sheen and central stripe. Females tend to keep the stripe as adults, but males are usually a plain coppery brown or gray, although some may have blue spots. The slow worm is a secretive animal, living in habitats that offer plenty of cover, and hiding under logs, flat stones, or piles of trash. It may occasionally bask during the day but is active mainly at dusk, when it emerges to feed on slugs and other invertebrates—a diet that makes it a useful visitor to gardens. Males become fiercely territorial during the breeding season and, after mating, the females give birth to 6–12 live young. Slow worms have a long lifespan, but in the north of their range, up to half of it is spent in hibernation.



Elgaria kingii

Arizona alligator lizard

Location S.W. USA, N.W. Mexico

Length 7½–12 in (19–30 cm)
Breeding Oviparous
Habit Terrestrial
Status Least concern

The Arizona alligator lizard has a light brown body, with darker crossbars, and a long tail. Its scales are shiny, and it has a fold of skin running along each flank. The lizard's long, slender body and short limbs are adaptations for moving quickly through grass and other dense vegetation. A secretive species, it is active throughout the day, and sometimes ventures out at dusk. It prefers to remain in moist areas in otherwise dry woodland, and in mountains and upland grassland, often near streams, where it forages among dead leaves and under debris for insects and spiders. It hibernates when food becomes scarce in winter. Preyed upon by snakes, birds, and small mammals, it discards its tail if grasped and may smear its enemy with feces. Alligator lizards live in loose colonies, the males becoming territorial during the breeding season. Females lay 9–12 eggs, buried in moist sand or soil; the hatchlings are boldly banded.